taking part in the discussion of the document, apart from Khrushchev himself, included government heavyweights: Frol Kozlov, the de facto second man in the party after Khrushchev; Leonid Brezhnev, the future Soviet leader, who then held the largely ceremonial office of chairman of the Supreme Soviet, the rubber-stamp parliament; Aleksei Kosygin, the future prime minister under Brezhnev and Khrushchev's first deputy in the government at the time; and Anastas Mikoyan, another first deputy of Khrushchev and the only member of the leadership who had voiced reservations about the plan. Once again, he was polite and respectful but critical of the idea concocted by Khrushchev and the proposal resulting from it.[9]

Faced with Mikoyan's continuing opposition, Khrushchev called on his ally Marshal Malinovsky, asking how long it would take him to overrun an island such as Cuba. What Khrushchev had in mind was not the speed with which Malinovsky could take the island under control so as to prevent an American invasion but the speed with which the Americans could capture the island. Malinovsky knew what was expected of him and suggested that it would take him roughly four days, perhaps a week. "Do you see?" Khrushchev told Mikoyan. "We have no other option." Khrushchev was expecting an American invasion and using the threat of it to cow the only dissident in the party and government leadership into submission. Still Mikoyan disagreed.

Mikoyan, who had visited Cuba a few years earlier, did not think that the operation could be kept secret and that the missiles, once deployed, could escape American detection. "I told him," recalled Mikoyan, "what I saw with my own eyes in 1960: no woods to hide missile launchers, just some palm trees too far away from each other." The palm trees were in fact "naked trees" with leaves only on top, continued Mikoyan. The members of the Presidium had visited the Black Sea resort of Sochi in the Soviet subtropics and knew what palm trees looked like. They had nothing to say in response. "I told them," said Mikoyan, "that the consequences could be dangerous or even catastrophic. The Americans could launch a strike on our missiles and destroy them in several minutes." He suggested that the leaders had to think about their next steps: "What would we have to do then? Just swallow that, look disgraced in front of the entire world and possibly lose